



Chronicles of Riddick: Assault on Dark Athena

Score: 6/10

Developer: Atari
Distributor: Milestone
Platforms: Xbox 360, PS3, PS2,
PC
Price: Rs. 999 (PC)



He won't attack if you are healing



Pity. They may become drones though.

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The disk comes with two games, *Assault on Dark Athena*, and a remastered version of the 2004 game, *Escape from Butcher Bay* as a bonus. *Escape from Butcher Bay* is a reworked version, with better graphics. *Escape from Dark Athena* is a sequel to the previous game. The game throws you in a beach with industrial surroundings. The initial level is a tutorial level to learn the controls of the game. When you crouch, everything turns blue, and you enter a stealth mode. There is a toggle for the nightshine – Riddick's trademark ability to see clearly in the dark. Everything gets really bright and purple in this mode, and it feels great initially

if you have seen either of the movies. In the introductory level, you come across a few "drones". These are something like remote-controlled android zombies. Nice concept for an army, only, they behave really dumb. Some of them just walk back and forth ignoring everything that you do. However, the first level sets the tone of the game, making sure that you sneak up on enemies instead of fighting them outright. You navigate across a few tunnels, and suddenly, everything goes black.

Someone must have kidnapped you and taken you aboard the ship – called Dark Athena. Pretty soon into the game, you receive a set of blades, which are your primary weapons for most of the game. For some strange reason, you are in a vent above the captain

(called Revas), and you reach out and pluck out her hairpin. There is no real explanation for this action, except when you return it to her well into the game. Why this happens, or if there is any deep symbolic meaning behind borrowing and returning a hairpin, we cannot say. The cutscenes that kick in at this point quickly become very boring and dreary. By the end of the game, it feels as if your head will explode if it hears the word "darkness" one more time. There might be a meaning to "in despair, I find opportunity", or something like that, but it makes no sense in the game whatsoever. Riddick has a dry, monotonous, dead voice throughout the game, with none of the mischief and the dry, sarcastic humor from the movies. Vin Diesel is thoroughly and completely

wasted as a voice actor in this one. You don't need a dark and brooding voice to say "tell me how to open the cells", that's just overkill.

The gameplay however, quickly gets to you. Despite all the drones with rotten AI, sneaking up to them and finishing them off with the blades is a pleasure. At least for the first third of the game, you get no real guns, only a tranquilizer dart gun. You have to navigate through the ship till you come across a kind of prison, where the captain and her mercenaries have kept a number of captives. This is where the game amps up a bit. The voice acting of all the secondary characters is amazing, and they really rile you up to go ahead with the game. For the next couple of hours, the gameplay takes you